MIS 430 — SYSTEMS ANALYSIS & DESIGN

Change Management: Stakeholder Analysis & Strategies

Parts 1 & 2 — Stakeholder Identification, Change Impact Analysis & Tailored Strategies

Project: Algorithmic Fairness & Transparency Portal — Music Streaming Recommendation Platform

PART 1

Stakeholder Identification & Change Impact Analysis

The deployment of the Algorithmic Fairness & Transparency Portal introduces significant operational, cultural, and strategic changes across multiple stakeholder groups. The following analysis identifies four key stakeholders, examining how the portal will reshape their daily work, what they stand to gain or lose, and how they are most likely to respond.

1 User Privacy Advocates & Regulators

Internal compliance officers, privacy advocates, external regulatory bodies, and user data rights organizations

POSITIVE IMPACT

CHANGES TO DAILY WORK

- Gain access to structured audit trails and fairness metrics that previously required manual investigation
- Can reference portal data when responding to regulatory inquiries or user complaints
- Shift from reactive compliance firefighting to proactive transparency monitoring

PERCEIVED BENEFITS

- Demonstrates organizational commitment to algorithmic accountability before regulation forces it
- Provides concrete, auditable evidence of fairness monitoring and bias detection
- Positions the organization favorably in emerging regulatory discussions around algorithmic transparency

PERCEIVED RISKS OR LOSSES

- Concern that user-facing explanations may inadvertently expose proprietary algorithm logic
- Risk that the appeal mechanism could create new legal exposure or liability pathways
- Worry that audit trail completeness may not meet evolving regulatory standards

LIKELY RESPONSE

Supportive with constructive caution. This group will broadly welcome the portal as a long-overdue step toward accountability. However, they will scrutinize the implementation details carefully, particularly around what information is disclosed to users versus what is retained internally. Expect detailed feedback on explanation wording and audit completeness rather than resistance to the initiative itself.

PART 2 — CHANGE STRATEGY

KEY CONCERNS & FEARS

- The portal may create a false sense of transparency without real enforcement mechanisms
- Explanation language could be vague enough to satisfy marketing but not rigorous enough for regulatory scrutiny
- Appeal outcomes may lack consistency, undermining credibility
- Audit metrics could be selectively presented rather than comprehensively disclosed

COMMUNICATION APPROACH

- Engage early with detailed technical briefings before public announcements
- Share draft explanation templates and audit methodologies for review and input
- Provide regular compliance status updates showing alignment with frameworks such as the EU AI Act and FTC algorithmic accountability guidelines
- Use formal written communication with supporting documentation rather than informal updates

ROLLOUT INVOLVEMENT

- Include as beta participants in Phase 1 to validate that transparency mechanisms meet regulatory standards
- Establish a standing review committee that evaluates portal disclosures quarterly
- Invite to co-author the external-facing transparency methodology documentation
- Provide a direct feedback channel to the product team during each rollout phase

TRAINING & SUPPORT NEEDS

- Walkthrough of the audit trail system and how to extract compliance reports
- Documentation mapping portal features to specific regulatory requirements
- Access to a sandbox environment for testing regulatory scenarios
- Quarterly briefing sessions as portal features evolve

2 Independent & Emerging Artists

Musicians not signed to major labels, emerging content creators, and artist advocacy organizations

POSITIVE IMPACT

CHANGES TO DAILY WORK

- Gain visibility into how the recommendation algorithm treats independent versus major-label content
- Access fairness metrics showing whether their content receives equitable exposure
- Can file appeals if they believe the algorithm is systematically disadvantaging their work

PERCEIVED BENEFITS

- First concrete mechanism to hold the platform accountable for algorithmic visibility bias
- Fairness audits may lead to real changes in how recommendations are weighted
- Appeal process provides a formal channel that did not previously exist

PERCEIVED RISKS OR LOSSES

- Portal could be perceived as "performative transparency" with monitoring but no meaningful action
- Fairness metrics may be defined in ways that technically satisfy equity goals without improving real outcomes
- Timeline to tangible impact on visibility may be long, eroding trust

LIKELY RESPONSE

Cautiously optimistic but watchful. Independent artists have long felt disadvantaged by opaque recommendation algorithms. They will welcome the transparency effort but will judge the portal almost entirely on outcomes: does it actually change how their music surfaces? Initial enthusiasm could quickly shift to frustration if fairness audits reveal bias but the platform does not act on the findings.

KEY CONCERNS & FEARS

- The portal will document bias without fixing it, becoming a PR exercise
- Fairness metrics may be designed around platform convenience rather than artist outcomes
- Major labels will still receive preferential algorithmic treatment behind the scenes
- The appeal process may be slow, opaque, or ultimately toothless

COMMUNICATION APPROACH

- Lead with concrete data: share specific fairness metrics and what they measure in plain language
- Publish regular "State of Fairness" reports with real numbers on independent artist visibility
- Use artist-community channels (newsletters, artist forums, social media) rather than corporate press releases
- Be transparent about limitations and timelines rather than overpromising

ROLLOUT INVOLVEMENT

- Recruit a diverse panel of independent artists for Phase 1 beta testing
- Establish an Artist Advisory Council that meets monthly during rollout
- Invite artist advocates to participate in fairness metric definition workshops
- Provide public commitments to act on findings from fairness audits with specific timelines

TRAINING & SUPPORT NEEDS

- Simple, visual tutorials on how to read fairness metrics and what they mean for individual artists
- Step-by-step guide for filing and tracking appeals
- FAQ addressing common concerns about how the recommendation algorithm works at a high level
- Dedicated support contact for artists experiencing portal usability issues

3 Platform Engineering & Algorithm Teams

Data scientists, ML engineers, recommendation system developers, and product managers for engagement metrics

RESISTANT

CHANGES TO DAILY WORK

- Must instrument recommendation pipelines to generate audit-ready decision logs and explanation metadata
- New operational responsibilities for maintaining fairness dashboards and processing appeal reviews
- Algorithm changes now require transparency impact assessments before deployment
- Feature velocity may slow as each release needs fairness and explanation compliance checks

PERCEIVED BENEFITS

- Structured logging improves overall system observability and debugging capability
- Fairness constraints can lead to more robust, less biased models over time
- External accountability may reduce internal political pressure to optimize only for engagement

PERCEIVED RISKS OR LOSSES

- Transparency requirements may expose proprietary algorithmic logic that competitors could reverse-engineer
- Fairness constraints could reduce recommendation quality and engagement metrics they are evaluated on
- Significant ongoing engineering effort to maintain audit trails and process appeals
- Fear of increased external scrutiny that may second-guess technical decisions

LIKELY RESPONSE

Resistant and skeptical. Engineering teams will view the portal as an operational burden that adds complexity without directly improving the systems they care about. They may express concerns through passive resistance: deprioritizing portal-related work, arguing that transparency requirements are technically infeasible, or framing fairness constraints as threats to product quality. The resistance is not ideological but practical, rooted in concerns about workload, performance trade-offs, and loss of technical autonomy.

PART 2 — CHANGE STRATEGY

KEY CONCERNS & FEARS

- Performance metrics they are evaluated on (engagement, click-through, session duration) may suffer under fairness constraints
- The portal will create an unfunded mandate where they absorb operational load without additional headcount
- Non-technical stakeholders will use portal data to question engineering decisions without understanding the trade-offs
- Transparency commitments will lock them into maintaining legacy explanation formats even as algorithms evolve

COMMUNICATION APPROACH

- Frame as a technical quality initiative, not a compliance burden: better logging, better observability, better models
- Present concrete data from other organizations where fairness constraints improved long-term model robustness
- Use technical channels (engineering all-hands, architecture review boards, internal tech talks) rather than top-down mandates
- Acknowledge the real trade-offs honestly rather than dismissing their concerns

ROLLOUT INVOLVEMENT

- Involve senior engineers in designing the audit trail architecture from the start to ensure technical ownership
- Let the team define what constitutes "reasonable" explanation granularity to protect proprietary logic
- Establish a joint engineering-product working group that co-owns the portal's technical roadmap
- Give the team authority to propose alternative implementations that achieve transparency goals more efficiently

TRAINING & SUPPORT NEEDS

- Dedicated onboarding for the audit trail and explanation APIs with code examples and integration guides
- Updated performance evaluation criteria that account for fairness and transparency work, not just engagement
- Additional headcount or contractor budget to absorb the ongoing operational load
- Regular engineering retrospectives to surface and resolve operational pain points with the portal

4 Executive & Business Leadership

C-suite executives, marketing and communications leadership, and strategic business decision-makers

MIXED IMPACT

CHANGES TO DAILY WORK

- Must allocate sustained budget and engineering resources to a non-revenue-generating initiative
- Need to develop messaging strategy around algorithmic transparency that satisfies both investors and regulators
- Will face new decision points when fairness audits reveal bias: act on findings or risk credibility damage

PERCEIVED BENEFITS

- Potential competitive differentiation as the first streaming platform with a public transparency portal
- Proactive regulatory positioning reduces risk of costly forced compliance later
- Strengthened brand trust could improve user retention and attract privacy-conscious users
- Demonstrates corporate responsibility leadership to investors and the public

PERCEIVED RISKS OR LOSSES

- Unclear ROI: engineering resources diverted from features with direct revenue impact
- If fairness audits reveal significant bias, the organization is publicly committed to addressing it, potentially at high cost
- Competitors may use transparency disclosures as competitive intelligence
- The portal could become a liability if perceived as inadequate or performative by advocacy groups

LIKELY RESPONSE

Strategically cautious with conditional support. Executives will view the portal through a risk-reward lens. They will support the initiative as long as it strengthens the brand and reduces regulatory exposure without significantly impacting revenue metrics. However, support may waver when the portal surfaces uncomfortable findings that require costly action. The key tension will be between wanting transparency as a brand advantage while fearing the operational and financial commitments it demands.

PART 2 — CHANGE STRATEGY

KEY CONCERNS & FEARS

- The portal will generate negative press if audits reveal bias rather than positive coverage for transparency leadership
- Ongoing costs will escalate as the portal matures and user expectations increase
- Competitors will gain insight into proprietary recommendation approaches without reciprocating
- Shareholder questions about resource allocation to non-revenue initiatives

COMMUNICATION APPROACH

- Lead with competitive positioning data: market research on consumer demand for algorithmic transparency
- Present a phased investment model with clear go/no-go decision points and defined budgets per phase
- Provide regular executive dashboards showing portal adoption, user trust metrics, and regulatory alignment
- Frame fairness findings as opportunities to lead rather than liabilities to manage

ROLLOUT INVOLVEMENT

- Present go/no-go recommendations at each phase transition with clear metrics and risk assessments
- Include in quarterly steering committee reviews rather than day-to-day operational decisions
- Provide advance briefings before any public-facing portal announcements or fairness reports
- Engage communications leadership early to develop messaging for different fairness audit outcomes

TRAINING & SUPPORT NEEDS

- Executive briefing on the regulatory landscape for algorithmic accountability and where it is heading
- Competitor analysis showing how peers are approaching algorithmic transparency
- Decision framework for responding to different fairness audit findings (pre-planned response playbooks)
- Investor-ready materials explaining the business case for the transparency initiative